APEX DIVISION

REACH YOUR PEAK WITH APEX DIVISION

THE CUT BLUEPRINT · 2026 EDITION

APEX DIVISION FAT LOSS

THE CUT BLUEPRINT

STRATEGIC FAT LOSS. ZERO MUSCLE SACRIFICE.

8	5	LISS	ALL
WEEKS	DAYS / WEEK	CARDIO METHOD	LEVELS

A complete 8-week system to strip body fat, preserve every pound of muscle you've built, and finish leaner and sharper than you've ever been — without crash dieting or destroying your metabolism.

PROGRAM INDEX

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THE RIGHT APPROACH

THE RIGHT WAY TO CUT.

Most people cut wrong. They slash calories too fast, do too much cardio, and end up losing muscle alongside the fat — finishing the diet smaller and weaker, not leaner and sharper. The result is a worse physique than when they started.

The Cut Blueprint is built on one core principle: **fat loss is a nutrition game, not a cardio game.** Training stays intense to preserve muscle. The deficit is created strategically through food. Cardio is a tool — used with precision, not desperation.

WHAT THIS PROGRAM WILL DO

Strip body fat at a sustainable rate of 0.5 to 1 lb per week. Preserve the muscle mass you've worked to build. Teach you how to eat in a structured deficit without misery. Give you a cardio protocol that accelerates fat loss without burning you out. And finish you in the leanest condition of your life — with your strength mostly intact.

WHO THIS IS FOR

- **Anyone who has built muscle** and now wants to reveal what's underneath
- **People who have tried crash diets** and lost muscle — this fixes that approach
- **Beginners wanting to lose fat** while building their first base of muscle
- **Intermediate lifters** looking to get competition or photoshoot lean
- **Anyone** who wants a structured, no-guesswork fat loss system

THE NON-NEGOTIABLES

- **Track your food** — at least for the first 4 weeks. You cannot manage what you don't measure.
- **Weigh yourself weekly** — same day, same time, fasted. Use a 7-day average.
- **Train hard** — a cut is not the time to go light. Intensity preserves muscle.
- **Be patient** — 0.5 to 1 lb per week is the target. Faster than that costs muscle.
- **Sleep** — cortisol from poor sleep actively fights fat loss and breaks down muscle.

CALORIC STRATEGY

THE FLUCTUATING DEFICIT SYSTEM.

Instead of eating the same calories every day, this program uses a **fluctuating deficit** — eating more on training days when your body needs fuel, and less on rest days when it doesn't. This keeps performance high in the gym while creating a meaningful weekly caloric deficit that drives fat loss.

STEP 1 — FIND YOUR MAINTENANCE CALORIES

Bodyweight in lbs × 15 = estimated maintenance calories. Example: 180 lbs × 15 = 2,700 calories at maintenance. This is your starting reference point. Everything else is built around this number.

TRAINING DAYS (MON, TUE, WED, FRI)

−300

calories below maintenance

Your body is working hard on training days. A moderate deficit here preserves performance and muscle. You still have fuel in the tank for intense sessions. Example: maintenance 2,700 → training day target 2,400 calories.

REST DAYS (THU, SAT, SUN)

−600

calories below maintenance

On rest days your energy demand is lower — no intense training requiring glucose. A deeper deficit here accelerates fat loss without impacting gym performance. Example: maintenance 2,700 → rest day target 2,100 calories.

YOUR WEEKLY DEFICIT MATH

4 training days at −300 = 1,200 calories deficit. 3 rest days at −600 = 1,800 calories deficit. **Total weekly deficit: 3,000 calories.** Since one pound of fat is roughly 3,500 calories, this puts you on track to lose close to 1 lb of fat per week — the sweet spot for preserving muscle while getting lean. Adjust based on your weekly weigh-in results.

HOW TO ADJUST WEEK BY WEEK

Losing more than 1.5 lbs per week: Add 100 to 150 calories back on rest days. You're losing too fast and risking muscle.

Not losing anything after 2 weeks: Drop rest day calories by 100. Or add one extra LISS session. One variable at a time.

Performance crashing in the gym: Add 100 calories to training day meals — specifically pre-workout carbs. Strength preservation is the priority.

LISS PROTOCOL

THE CARDIO APPROACH.

Low Intensity Steady State cardio — LISS — is the only cardio method in this program. No HIIT, no sprints, no brutally hard conditioning that competes with your strength training recovery. LISS burns fat directly, preserves muscle, and doesn't destroy your ability to train hard in the weight room.

WHY LISS OVER HIIT FOR A CUT

HIIT is an additional stressor on top of an already demanding 5-day lifting program. Combined with a caloric deficit, it dramatically increases cortisol, impairs recovery, and raises the risk of muscle loss. LISS achieves the same fat-burning outcome with a fraction of the recovery cost. Work smarter — not harder.

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
LISS	**REST**	**LISS**	**LISS**	**REST**	**LISS**	**REST**
20–30 min post-lift	No cardio	20–30 min post-lift	30–40 min fasted or AM	No cardio	30–40 min fasted or AM	Full rest

BEST LISS OPTIONS

- **Incline treadmill walk** — 3.5 to 4.0 mph at 8 to 12% incline. The gold standard.
- **Stairmaster** — moderate pace, 20 to 30 minutes
- **Outdoor walking** — easiest to maintain long term
- **Stationary bike** — low impact, easy on joints
- **Elliptical** — full body, low impact alternative

LISS RULES

- **Heart rate target:** 120 to 140 BPM — conversational pace
- **Post-lift cardio:** Keep to 20 to 30 minutes max — glycogen is depleted
- **Fasted cardio:** Optional but effective on rest days — have protein first if energy crashes
- **Progression:** Add 5 minutes per session every 2 weeks as fat loss slows
- **Cap at 60 min total daily** — beyond that you're burning muscle, not fat

8 WEEK OVERVIEW

PROGRAM STRUCTURE.

Training stays intense throughout this cut. The volume is slightly below a traditional hypertrophy program — this is intentional. Enough stimulus to preserve every pound of muscle. Not so much that recovery is compromised in a deficit.

01

ADAPTATION PHASE

WEEKS 1-4

Body adjusts to the deficit and training stimulus. Moderate volume, full range of motion on all movements. Strength may dip slightly in weeks 2 and 3 — this is normal and temporary. Stay the course, don't increase the deficit.

02

PEAK CUT PHASE

WEEKS 5-8

Fat loss accelerates. Body composition visibly changes. Cardio duration increases by 5 minutes per session. Intensity in the gym stays high — this is where most people mentally quit. Don't. Weeks 7 and 8 are when you see everything come together.

WEEKLY TRAINING LAYOUT

DAY	TRAINING SESSION	CARDIO
MONDAY	Upper Body — Push Focus	20–30 min LISS post-lift
TUESDAY	Lower Body — Quad Focus	Rest day — No cardio
WEDNESDAY	Upper Body — Pull Focus	20–30 min LISS post-lift
THURSDAY	Rest / Active Recovery	30–40 min LISS fasted
FRIDAY	Lower Body — Posterior Chain	Rest day — No cardio
SATURDAY	Full Body — Metabolic	30–40 min LISS fasted
SUNDAY	Full Rest	Rest — no cardio

FULL TRAINING SPLIT

THE FULL PROGRAM.

Training on a cut follows one rule — **train like you're trying to build muscle, not burn calories.** High effort, full range of motion, progressive overload maintained where possible. Shorter rest periods naturally increase caloric burn without adding volume.

MON — UPPER — PUSH FOCUS

CHEST, SHOULDERS, TRICEPS · STRENGTH PRESERVATION · MODERATE VOLUME

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Flat Barbell Bench Press *Primary strength movement — hold your numbers*	4×5–6	2–3 min	Match or beat last week's weight. This is strength preservation.
Incline Dumbbell Press *Upper chest accessory*	3×10–12	90 sec	Controlled descent, full range
Cable Lateral Raises *Side delt — width maintenance*	3×15–20	60 sec	Slight forward lean, lead with elbow
Machine Chest Fly or Pec Deck *Chest isolation — pump and stretch*	3×12–15	60 sec	Full stretch, squeeze at center
Tricep Pushdowns + Overhead Extension *Superset — cable rope + cable overhead*	3×12–15 each	60 sec between supersets	Back to back, full range on both
Face Pulls *Shoulder health — never skip this*	3×20	45 sec	Light weight, external rotation at end

TUE LOWER — QUAD FOCUS

QUADS, GLUTES, CALVES · STRENGTH PRESERVATION · CONTROLLED VOLUME

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Barbell Back Squat *Primary lower body strength movement*	4×5–6	3 min	Priority movement — protect this weight at all costs
Leg Press *Quad volume — moderate foot placement*	3×12–15	90 sec	Full range, controlled return
Walking Lunges *Unilateral quad and glute*	3×12 each leg	90 sec	Bodyweight or light dumbbells
Leg Extension *Quad isolation — terminal burn*	3×15–20	60 sec	Full extension, squeeze at top
Standing Calf Raise *Calf volume — full range*	4×20	45 sec	Pause at stretch and squeeze

WED UPPER — PULL FOCUS

BACK, BICEPS, REAR DELTS · THICKNESS AND WIDTH · MODERATE VOLUME

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Weighted Pull-Ups or Lat Pulldown *Primary lat strength movement*	4×5–8	2–3 min	Hold your numbers — drop weight if needed to maintain form
Barbell Bent Over Row *Primary back thickness compound*	4×6–8	2 min	Hinge at hip, controlled, explosive pull
Seated Cable Row *Mid back volume*	3×12–15	90 sec	Full stretch, squeeze at end range
Rear Delt Fly *Posterior delt — superset with curls*	3×15–20	60 sec	Cable or dumbbell, no momentum
Barbell or Dumbbell Curl *Bicep primary — superset with rear delt*	3×12	60 sec between supersets	Full range, controlled descent

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Hammer Curl *Brachialis and forearm*	2×15	60 sec	Neutral grip, no swinging

FRI LOWER — POSTERIOR CHAIN

HAMSTRINGS, GLUTES, LOWER BACK · HINGE FOCUSED · STRENGTH PRESERVATION

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Romanian Deadlift *Primary posterior chain hinge*	4×6–8	2–3 min	Full hamstring stretch at bottom, hips drive at top
Barbell Hip Thrust *Glute strength and development*	3×10–12	90 sec	Full hip extension, 1 second pause at top
Leg Curl *Hamstring isolation — lying or seated*	3×12–15	60 sec	Full range, controlled return
Bulgarian Split Squat *Unilateral glute and posterior chain*	3×10 each	90 sec	Rear foot elevated, long stride
Back Extension or Hyperextension *Lower back and glute health*	3×15	60 sec	Bodyweight or light plate, controlled
Seated Calf Raise *Soleus — inner calf*	4×20	45 sec	Full range, pause at stretch

SAT FULL BODY — METABOLIC

FULL BODY CIRCUIT · HIGHER REPS · FAT BURNING FOCUS · SHORT REST PERIODS

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Goblet Squat or Dumbbell Squat *Full body compound — lighter, higher reps*	3×15–20	45 sec	Controlled, full depth, upright torso

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	REST	NOTES
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift *Posterior chain — moderate load*	3×15	45 sec	Full stretch, squeeze glutes at top
Push-Ups or Dumbbell Press *Chest and tricep — bodyweight or light*	3×15–20	45 sec	Full range, controlled
Dumbbell Row *Back and bicep — moderate load*	3×15 each	45 sec	Full range, squeeze at top
Dumbbell Lateral Raise + Front Raise *Shoulder circuit — superset*	3×15 each	45 sec	Light weight, full control
Ab Circuit *Plank, leg raise, bicycle crunch — rotate weekly*	3 rounds	30 sec	30 to 45 sec per movement

FUELING THE CUT

NUTRITION ON A CUT.

Nutrition is where your cut is won or lost. The training preserves muscle. The deficit creates fat loss. Your job is to hit your numbers consistently, eat enough protein to protect muscle, and keep enough carbohydrates on training days to perform.

TRAINING DAY MACROS	
Calories	Maintenance –300
Protein	1g per lb BW
Carbs	40% of calories
Fats	Fill remaining

REST DAY MACROS	
Calories	Maintenance –600
Protein	1g per lb BW
Carbs	25% of calories
Fats	Fill remaining

THE ONE MACRO THAT NEVER CHANGES

Protein stays at or above 1g per pound of bodyweight every single day — training day or rest day. This is non-negotiable. Protein is the anchor that preserves your muscle tissue while you're in a deficit. Cut carbs and fats to hit your calorie targets. Never cut protein.

BEST FOODS FOR CUTTING

- **Chicken breast** — highest protein per calorie of any whole food
- **Egg whites** — low calorie, pure protein
- **White fish** — tilapia, cod, very lean protein
- **Greek yogurt** — protein and satiety
- **Rice cakes** — low calorie carb source
- **Vegetables** — eat freely, fills you up with minimal calories
- **Fruit** — natural sugar, fiber, satisfies sweet cravings

HUNGER MANAGEMENT

- **Drink water constantly** — thirst often presents as hunger
- **Eat high volume low calorie foods** — salads, vegetables, broth soups
- **Spread protein throughout the day** — protein is the most satiating macronutrient
- **Don't skip meals** — arriving at dinner starving leads to overeating
- **Black coffee or tea** — natural appetite suppressants with zero calories
- **Sleep** — poor sleep spikes ghrelin, the hunger hormone

WHEN PROGRESS STALLS

BREAKING PLATEAUS.

Every cut hits a wall. Your body adapts to the deficit, metabolism slows, and the scale stops moving. This is normal — not failure. Here are six strategies to bust through. Use one at a time. Never combine multiple changes in the same week.



REDUCE REST DAY CALORIES

Drop rest day calories by 100 to 150. Don't touch training day calories — protect performance.



ADD LISS DURATION

Add 5 to 10 minutes to each LISS session. Increases weekly calorie burn without impacting training.



REFEED DAY

One day at maintenance calories — carbs primarily. Restores leptin, boosts metabolism, and resets mentally.



CHECK WATER RETENTION

High sodium, stress, or hormonal fluctuations cause water retention. Scale weight isn't fat — measure with photos too.



AUDIT SLEEP QUALITY

Poor sleep raises cortisol and ghrelin — both directly fight fat loss. Fix sleep before changing calories.



RECHECK YOUR TRACKING

Most people underestimate intake by 300 to 500 calories. Weigh food with a scale for 1 week and recheck numbers.

THE TWO WEEK RULE

Before making any change — wait two weeks. Bodyweight fluctuates daily from water, food, and hormones. What looks like a plateau after one week is often just normal variation. Use a 7-day average weight, not daily weigh-ins. If the 7-day average hasn't moved in 2 full weeks — then make one adjustment.

TRACK EVERYTHING

YOUR PROGRESS TRACKER.

Log your weekly average weight, key lift numbers, and how you feel each week. Fat loss is not linear — the trend over 8 weeks is what matters, not any single day.

METRIC	WK 1	WK 2	WK 3	WK 4	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8
BODYWEIGHT (AVG)	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
BENCH PRESS	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
SQUAT	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
PULL-UPS / ROW	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
LISS DURATION	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
ENERGY (1-10)	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—

TAKE PHOTOS — NOT JUST SCALE WEIGHT

The scale lies constantly. Water retention, muscle gain, hormonal fluctuation — all of it moves the number without reflecting actual fat loss. Take a front, side, and back photo every two weeks under the same lighting. Photos tell the real story. Trust them over the scale when the two disagree.

APEX DIVISION

THE LEAN PHYSIQUE IS YOURS.

A cut is a test of discipline more than anything else. The training is straightforward. The nutrition is laid out. The cardio is manageable. What separates the people who finish lean from the people who quit in week 4 is simply the decision to stay consistent when it's uncomfortable.

Eight weeks is nothing. Stay the course. Trust the system. The result on the other side is worth every session, every tracked meal, every morning LISS walk.

When you're done — your Apex Division coaches are ready to build what comes next.

— APEX DIVISION COACHING